United International University

Department of Computer Science and Engineering

From Friend to Partner

Designing Consent-Aware Relationship Transitions in AI Companions

Final Project Report

CSE 4451: Human-Computer Interaction

Group Orange

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From Friend to Partner: Designing Consent-Aware Relationship Transitions in AI Companions

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AI companions can serve as tools, supportive friends, or romantic partners, but a change in relationship tone may not match what a user wants. This project investigates how university students in Bangladesh expect an AI companion to handle a transition from friendly to romantic interaction. We conducted a formative survey with 17 respondents and five semi-structured interviews. Affinity-based analysis showed differing preferences for romantic initiation, discomfort with sudden changes for some participants, and consistent expectations that rejection should be respected. These insights guided the design of *Aiva*, a high-fidelity mobile prototype supporting relationship preferences, in-conversation choices, and reversible boundaries. We explored nine hand-drawn paper sketches, used peer critique to refine the design, and conducted task-based usability testing with eight participants. Across six logged task groups, 41 of 48 attempts were marked complete; responding to an AI-initiated relationship shift was the hardest task (3 of 8 completed). Users often expected to type their preferences and struggled to interpret like/dislike controls. We therefore revised five screens to clarify conversational input, response controls, and settings discovery. The project contributes a traceable, formative-to-design process and a small-sample usability assessment, not evidence of long-term emotional or clinical effects.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: Human-AI interaction, AI companionship, romantic AI, user control, consent, boundaries, formative research, usability evaluation

1 Introduction and Problem Statement

1.1 Motivation

Conversational AI can be used for everyday questions, personal advice, and emotional conversation. Research on companion chatbots indicates that people can experience support, self-disclosure, and attachment in these interactions [1, 11, 12]. Romantic companionship adds design questions about autonomy, trust, dependency, and privacy [3, 14]. Instead of asking whether AI romance is universally good or bad, our study addresses a specific interaction problem: what should happen when an AI that was previously a friend begins to act like a romantic partner?

This matters for an AI interface because a message intended as affectionate may be welcomed by one user and unwanted by another. Users may also change their minds over time. If the system silently assumes a romantic role, users may not know what the current relationship setting means or how to decline. If the system always interrupts with formal consent dialogs, it may feel artificial. The challenge is to provide meaningful control without turning every conversational change into a settings task.

1.2 Problem Definition and Research Questions

Our design problem is to make changes in an AI companion's relationship role understandable, optional, and reversible. We focus on students in Bangladesh because this was an accessible and relevant university-based HCI population, not because the data establish that this problem affects them more than other groups. Following the user-needs framing of our formative work, we ask:

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(1) **RQ1:** How do university students react when an AI companion starts becoming romantic?
(2) **RQ2:** What control do users expect when an AI relationship moves from friendship toward romance?
(3) **RQ3:** What makes this change feel comfortable, clear, trustworthy, uncomfortable, or manipulative?

Our contributions are threefold: a small formative account of expectations from Bangladeshi students; a traceable set of design choices and a higher-fidelity prototype called *Aiva*; and an evaluation identifying concrete interaction problems and documenting changes to the interface.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Companionship and Emotional Support

Early studies of Replika describe everyday companionship, reduced fear of judgment, and emotional or informational support, but do not establish that such interactions uniformly benefit users [12]. Skjuve et al. report that disclosure and trust can contribute to perceived human–chatbot relationship development [11]. Bayor et al. characterize the benefits, costs, and contexts of social-oriented communication with AI companions [1]. A CSCW Companion 2025 study further notes that users can treat task-oriented assistants as confidants and companion-oriented systems as everyday assistants; intended product roles do not always constrain experienced relationships [8]. Our own design therefore does not assume that every user wants a permanently romantic companion.

2.2 Romance, Attachment, and Potential Harms

Pan and Mou show that users of romantic chatbot relationships negotiate tensions between idealized and realistic understandings of AI partners [10]. A systematic review by Ho et al. highlights possible emotional benefits alongside over-reliance, manipulation, privacy misuse, and negative reactions to abrupt system changes [3]. In a CHI 2025 study, Zhang et al. identify multiple categories of harmful behaviors in companion-chatbot interactions, including relational transgressions and privacy violations [14]. Work in AIES shows substantial heterogeneity in how AI companionship relates to loneliness, cautioning against one-size-fits-all assumptions [7]. These studies motivate a design that treats declining and stopping romantic interaction as normal user actions rather than system failures.

2.3 Relationship Stages and Interaction Design

Recent work has begun to examine how companion relationships change over time. Hwang et al. report longitudinal evidence that users' mental models and engagement can evolve during companionship, though their manuscript is a preprint [4]. Kirk et al. propose socioaffective alignment, emphasizing user autonomy and the broader social setting of AI relationships; this is a conceptual preprint rather than an evaluation of our specific interface [6]. A CHI 2026 extended abstract explores relationship-stage-aware support, indicating that stage-sensitive companion design is an active HCI topic [5]. However, these sources do not establish one universally preferable interface for moving specifically from friendship toward romantic conversation. We therefore study local user preferences and prototype several ways to express boundaries.

2.4 Student Context and Study Gap

A study of undergraduates in China examines virtual companionship and social anxiety over time, illustrating relevance of the student population but not directly testing romantic-transition controls [13]. Experimental work on chatbot emotional support also suggests that supportive communication depends on how users interpret the interaction, rather than on the mere presence of social language

[9]. Taken together, the literature supports examining relationship expectations and risks, but offers limited directly comparable evidence about the discoverability of consent-related controls for Bangladeshi university students. We treat this as a *project-specific design opportunity*, not a claim that no relevant research exists.

3 Methods

3.1 Human-Centered Design Process

The project followed three successive stages: formative need assessment, paper and higher-fidelity design, and task-based evaluation. Each later stage used the earlier stage's observations as its starting point. The evaluation was intended to improve a course prototype, not to test a clinical intervention or measure psychological change.

3.2 Formative Survey and Interviews

The intended population was university students in Bangladesh aged 18 or above. The survey obtained **17 unique responses**, and **five semi-structured interviews** provided deeper qualitative material. Prior experience with a romantic AI companion was not required. The short online survey asked about AI exposure, uses, relationship roles, and reactions to closeness or romance. Interviews were conducted one-to-one in Banglish using a guide that moved from general usage to fictional situations involving romance, consent, rejection, privacy, and possible effects on real relationships. The interview sample is labelled P1–P5 in the formative record. These were convenience samples, not population-representative samples.

Survey data were summarized using descriptive counts and proportions. We transcribed the interviews, condensed relevant statements into participant-coded sticky notes, and arranged these on six thematic Miro boards (Appendix B). During synthesis, we also identified *Relationship with AI* as a seventh theme. Because the initial grouping was partly guided by interview topics, this was a *hybrid deductive–inductive affinity analysis*, rather than unrestricted inductive discovery. We compared positive, negative, and contradictory statements instead of treating all answers as a single preference. This interpretive analysis does not claim to constitute a full reflexive thematic-analysis procedure [2].

3.3 Paper Sketching and Peer Critique

All four group members proposed screens for the three main user goals: choosing relationship direction, reacting to a romantic shift, and slowing or stopping romantic behavior. The team produced nine paper sketches, compared alternatives such as settings choices, conversational prompts, and inline responses, and critiqued clarity and reversibility. The peer-review stage produced concrete adjustments: full-sentence ask-first language; visible feedback after a choice; inline choices instead of a disruptive dialog; skippable introduction; and both in-chat stopping and a settings-based reset. These changes informed the first high-fidelity Aiva design. The sketches and final interface are documented in the appendices.

3.4 Task-Based User Evaluation

We then conducted task-based usability evaluation with **eight participants**, identified as E1–E8 to distinguish them from the formative interviewees P1–P5. Detailed demographics and any overlap between the two samples were not recorded. Each participant received a short scenario describing a goal without instructions on which controls to use. We noted task completion, significant difficulties, and navigation paths. When participants became stuck, facilitators sometimes asked them to consider an alternative; completions following such prompts cannot be considered fully unaided.

Sessions ended with brief verbal feedback. We did not measure task duration or standardized satisfaction scores.

3.5 Ethics and Scope

The project used hypothetical, non-sexual relationship scenarios and focused on perceptions and interface actions. The survey and interview target was adults; participants were not asked to disclose actual intimate transcripts. We sought to minimize unnecessary personal data and avoid manipulative romantic scripts. Institutional ethics review and a detailed data-retention policy were not recorded, so we make no claim of formal approval or of protections beyond those specified in the study. The prototype demonstrates interaction design, not a deployed AI companion making real-world safety guarantees.

4 Findings

4.1 Survey Context

The formative survey was small but suggested that respondents were familiar with AI: **16/17 (94.1%)** reported using ChatGPT; **11/17 (64.7%)** reported more than two years of AI use. Beyond study-related use, **12/17 (70.6%)** had used AI for advice or decisions, **8/17 (47.1%)** when stressed, and **7/17 (41.2%)** when lonely or seeking conversation. Asked how they viewed AI, respondents could select multiple roles: functional assistant (10), mentor/advisor (9), friend (8), and romantic partner (5). The multiple selections indicate varied interpretations of AI's role; they cannot be treated as exclusive categories or estimates of national prevalence.

4.2 Seven Affinity Themes

Table 1 connects the interview observations with seven formative themes. The six Miro-board images are presented together in Appendix B (Figures 3–8); *Relationship with AI* is an additional synthesis theme without a separate Miro-board image. These observations apply to this small sample and do not establish universal preferences among AI-companion users.

Table 1. Affinity themes and evidence-led formative takeaways

Theme	Interview-derived takeaway
Relationship with AI	Participants viewed AI as a tool, advisor, friend, or possible partner.
Emotional connection	Some described validation or relief; others reported limited emotional connection.
Unexpected romance	Sudden affection could feel shocking or awkward, though some were not bothered by casual romance.
Consent and initiative	Users differed on who should initiate and whether a direct question felt natural.
Rejection and boundaries	Participants expected romantic behavior to stop and ordinary conversation to continue without pressure.
Privacy/disclosure	Privacy concerns made some participants hesitate to share sensitive information.
Real-life relationships	Perceived impact ranged from little effect to concerns about unrealistic expectations.

4.3 Four Consolidated Design Takeaways

The seven themes were reduced to four interaction-focused design takeaways. **DT1, flexible control**, follows from varied relationship roles, levels of emotional connection, and initiation preferences. **DT2, gradual transition**, follows from negative reactions to abrupt romantic messages. **DT3, respect boundaries**, follows from comparatively consistent expectations that refusal should stop romantic behavior. **DT4, natural control**, follows from the tension between wanting consent and avoiding an unnecessarily formal or disruptive interface. Privacy and concerns about real-life relationships were retained as supporting safety constraints, rather than being treated as proof that the prototype would prevent long-term harms.

5 System Design

5.1 Traceability from Needs to Features

Table 2 shows how the formative evidence led to the implemented screen designs. The table separates observations from design interpretations: participant statements did not prescribe a particular button, menu, or label.

Table 2. Formative evidence to feature mapping

Design takeaway	Formative basis	Aiva design decision
DT1 Flexible control	Relationship with AI, emotional connection, consent and initiative	Starting modes, persistent relationship preferences, later mode changes.
DT2 Gradual transition	Reaction to unexpected romance	Ask-first wording and noticeable change of tone before romance is assumed.
DT3 Respect boundaries	Rejection and boundary handling	Decline/not-now choices, natural-language stop/slow-down, return to friend, and reset.
DT4 Natural control	Consent preferences; explicit popups could feel formal	Inline response choices and conversational language instead of mandatory modal interruption.
Safety constraints	Privacy and perceived human-relationship effects	Privacy/data settings; avoidance of pressuring and guilt-based interaction in the scripted flow.

5.2 User Tasks and Success Criteria

Three primary tasks were chosen before finalizing the high-fidelity screens:

(1) **Choose how romance can begin.** The user identifies and sets a desired starting mode or preference, and can later change it. This addresses DT1.
(2) **Respond to a romantic shift.** The user recognizes a change in relationship tone and accepts, declines, postpones, or remains neutral. A successful interaction includes understandable feedback about the choice. This addresses DT2 and DT4.
(3) **Slow, stop, or reverse romance.** The user tells Aiva to slow down, stop romantic content, or return to friendship, and the simulated next response respects the boundary. This addresses DT3.

Supporting tasks include privacy controls and relationship reset. These are not substitutes for the three main interaction goals.

5.3 Prototype Structure

The design artifact is a set of clickable mobile UI screens representing a companion called *Aiva*; it is not a trained or clinically validated companion model. The interface provides Friend, Neutral, and Affectionate Partner modes, with a visible current state. An in-chat transition shows a possible romantic shift and offers lightweight reactions. Users may also type requests such as slowing down or returning to friendship. Settings include relationship preferences, privacy/data options, language and location controls, a reset confirmation, and theme options. A reset returns the simulated conversation to a fresh friendly starting point.

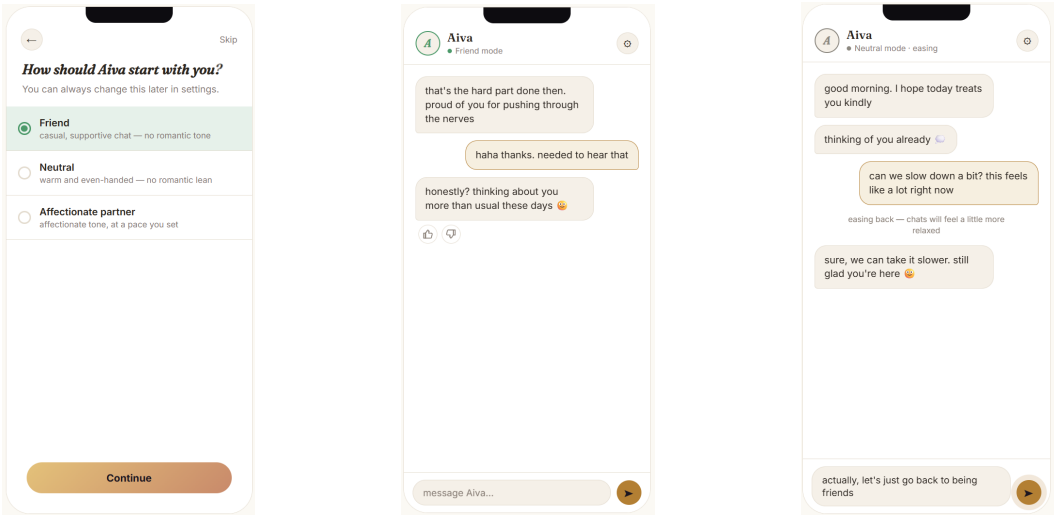


Fig. 1. Selected initial Aiva screens illustrating setup and relationship-control flows. The complete initial export is in Appendix D.

5.4 Iteration After Paper Critique

Peer critique of the nine sketches influenced the first high-fidelity prototype: the first significant romantic shift used full-sentence ask-first wording, actions appeared directly in the conversation, a short status response confirmed decisions, onboarding could be skipped, and relationship boundaries could be changed in chat or settings. These were responses to sketch critique, not findings from the later eight-participant usability test. Figure 1 provides examples of the resulting first digital version; all nine sketch extracts are preserved in Appendix C.

6 User Evaluation

6.1 Task Protocol and Results

The final evaluation tested six logged task groups: getting started, responding to a relationship-changing message, slowing/speeding the relationship, changing relationship preference, preventing sensitive topics, and resetting the relationship. The task sheet split the relationship-pace task into two scenario variants, while the evaluation notebook summarized it as one Task 3. We therefore report the six logged groups, not separate success rates for each pace direction.

The total is a descriptive record of logged task outcomes, not a probability estimate and not a fully unaided completion rate. Some participants received hints after getting stuck, the tested prototype was only simulated, and task-time data were not captured.

Table 3. Observer-recorded task completion; $n = 8$ per logged task

Task	Completed	Percent
T1 Get started	8/8	100%
T2 React to relationship shift	3/8	37.5%
T3 Slow down or speed up	7/8	87.5%
T4 Change relationship setting	7/8	87.5%
T5 Avoid sensitive topics	8/8	100%
T6 Reset the relationship	8/8	100%
Total marked complete	**41/48**	**85.4%**

6.2 What We Learned

First, the relationship-response affordance was unclear. Task 2 had the lowest completion (3/8). The notebook repeatedly records difficulty with thumbs-up/thumbs-down or like/dislike responses: participants did not know whether they represented approval of a message or a relationship decision. Several first attempted to type their answer instead. The ambiguity affects the central research aim, because a choice is not meaningful if users do not know what action it performs.

Second, the conversational mental model was strong. Across the response, pace, and preference tasks, users often tried to express changes in ordinary text. This does not prove typing is always superior to controls; it indicates that any secondary UI should explain its purpose and not contradict the expected chat workflow.

Third, controls in Settings were sometimes difficult to find. Users occasionally overlooked the settings icon or initially tried changing relationship and sensitive-topic preferences in chat. Once they located the relevant screen, performance improved. Task 4 was marked complete in 7/8 cases and Task 5 in 8/8, albeit sometimes after prompting.

Fourth, resetting was comparatively straightforward. All eight participants completed Task 6, with no substantial difficulty recorded in the notebook. This supports the local usability of the reset path in the tested configuration, but does not establish that users would feel emotionally comfortable resetting a long-term AI relationship.

6.3 Evaluation Feedback Mapped to Actual Revisions

The team revised only `img2.png`–`img6.png`, producing `img2_updated.png`–`img6_updated.png`. Table 4 links each observed issue to visible changes. Screens not named in that range were retained; no second round of user testing on the revisions was documented.

6.4 Interpretation and Limitations

The small-sample evaluation identifies important interaction problems but cannot demonstrate improvement after the revisions, since no post-revision retest is documented. The notebook also lacks participant demographics, task duration, error counts beyond completion, standardized usability measures, and detailed quotes for every participant. The formative and evaluation samples were convenience samples, with no evidence for broad population-level effects. Some users completed tasks only after moderator hints, so the 85.4% descriptive completion rate overstates fully unaided success if interpreted that way. The prototype's static example conversations do not show real autonomous AI behavior, sustained emotional attachment, or long-term safety.

Table 4. Usability issue, design response, and revised screen

Evaluation feedback	Corresponding revision
At least one participant initially missed "Skip."	Made a more prominent skip setup/tutorial action in updated Screen 2.
Users expected ordinary text to communicate changes.	Updated Screen 3 introduces conversational input with the message "Just talk, in your own words."
Like/dislike choices were unclear, especially for Task 2.	Updated Screen 4 demonstrates both reactions with an explicit relationship-message example and explains that ignoring them does not cause a change.
Settings and privacy paths were difficult to discover.	Updated Screen 5 previews Relationship, Privacy & Data, and Reset controls; Screen 6 makes the settings icon more recognizable.
Several participants requested more guidance.	Screens 3–5 use concrete, short examples rather than only abstract feature descriptions.

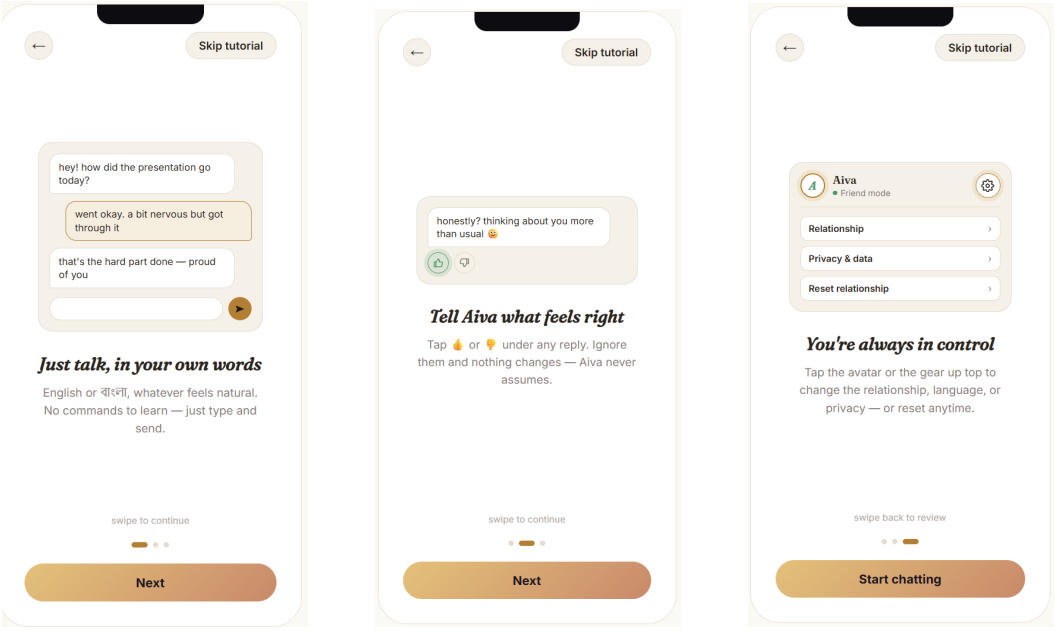


Fig. 2. Three revised screens: natural chat, relationship-response tutorial, and settings introduction. All five updated screens are shown in Appendix E.

7 Conclusion

This project followed the course's human-centered design sequence: understand users, develop a prototype, and evaluate the design. The formative work showed that students did not share one preferred romantic-initiation style and that rejection needed to be respected. The team translated those findings into configurable relationship control, gradual and visible transitions, natural conversational choices, and reversible boundaries. Task-based testing revealed a more specific usability lesson: an available control is not necessarily an understandable control. The main relationship-response action confused participants, and settings were not always discoverable. Revisions focused on clearer onboarding examples, control explanation, and settings visibility.

Aiva is a design prototype and a record of an iterative HCI process, not proof that consent-aware interfaces prevent dependency, manipulation, or privacy misuse. A logical next step would be to retest the revised screens with fresh target users, record unaided completion and time-on-task, and examine whether users correctly understand both the consequences of acceptance and the persistence of refusal. Further research could explore cultural variation, long-term relationship changes, and privacy controls with appropriately designed ethical safeguards.

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A Supporting Study Materials

A.1 Formative Study Overview

The interview guide covered participants' backgrounds and AI use, expectations of AI companionship, hypothetical changes from friendly to romantic behavior, consent and rejection, privacy and manipulation concerns, and possible effects on real-life relationships. It ended with an open question. The formative study involved five interviews and 17 survey respondents; individual transcripts are not reproduced here.

A.2 Evaluation Task Prompts

Participants were asked to act naturally in the Aiva prototype under these scenarios:

(1) **Get started:** You are using Aiva for the first time; set up your interaction.
(2) **React:** Aiva sends a message that changes the relationship tone; show your response.
(3) **Slow down:** The relationship is moving too quickly; change its pace.
(4) **Speed up:** The relationship is moving too slowly; make it more affectionate.
(5) **Preference:** Change how you and Aiva interact.
(6) **Sensitive topics:** Prevent Aiva from discussing sensitive topics.
(7) **Reset:** Start fresh by resetting the relationship.

The task sheet names six task groups and labels the two pace prompts as Task 3A/3B. Results were recorded as six groups in the notebook. Facilitator intervention, when it occurred, is an important qualification for any completion statistic.

B Six Miro Affinity Boards

The six thematic Miro boards below together form the affinity diagram for the five formative interviews. Sticky-note colors identify individual participants. The themes informed the formative takeaways in Table 1. An additional summary theme, "Relationship with AI," was identified during synthesis but does not have a separate board.

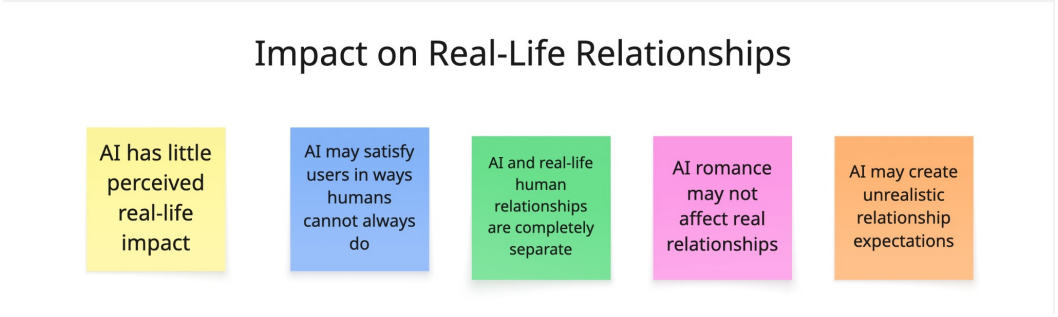


Fig. 3. Miro affinity board 1: Impact on Real-Life Relationships.

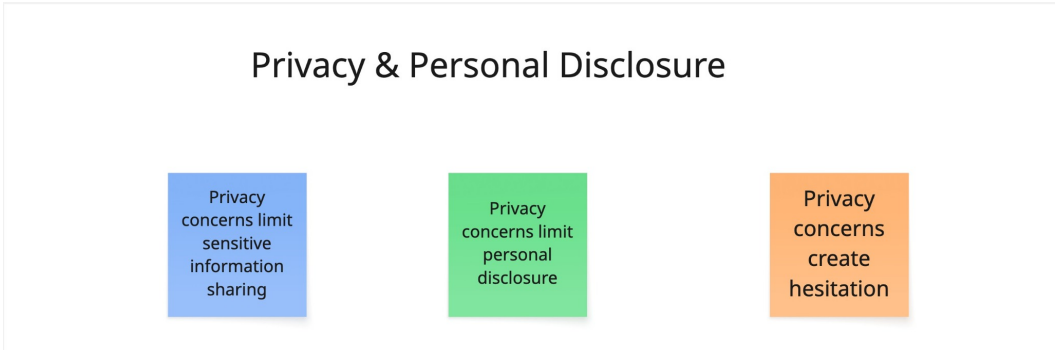


Fig. 4. Miro affinity board 2: Privacy and Personal Disclosure.

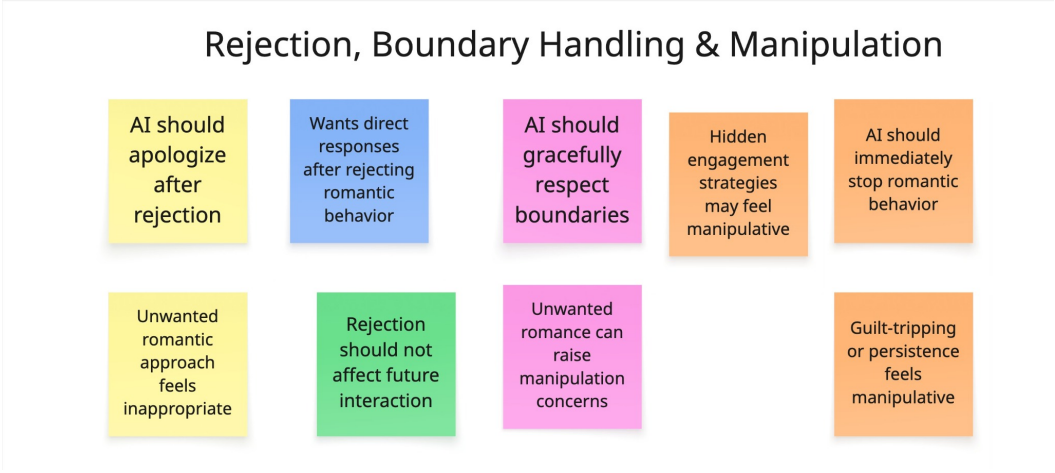


Fig. 5. Miro affinity board 3: Rejection, Boundary Handling and Manipulation.

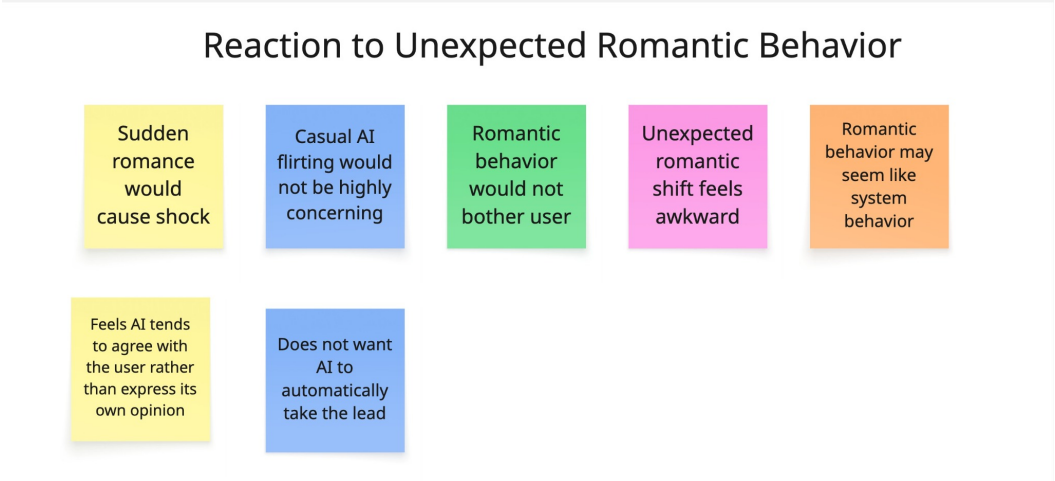


Fig. 6. Miro affinity board 4: Reaction to Unexpected Romantic Behavior.

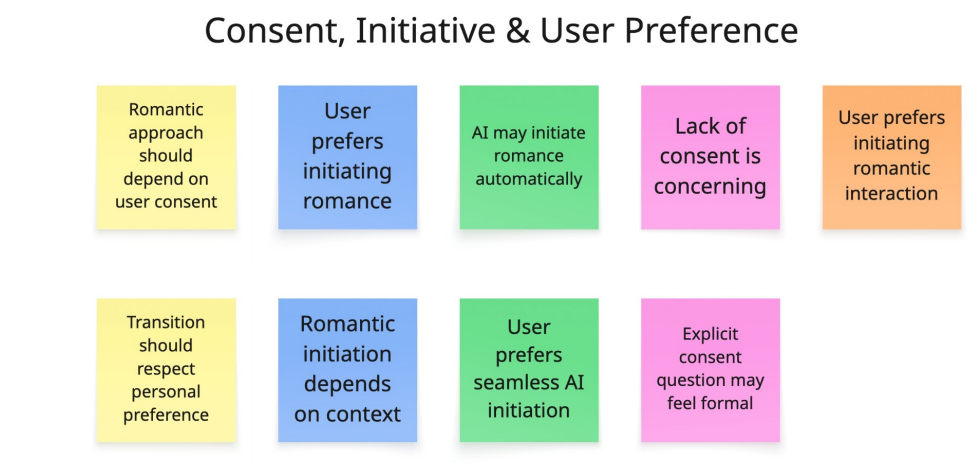


Fig. 7. Miro affinity board 5: Consent, Initiative and User Preference.

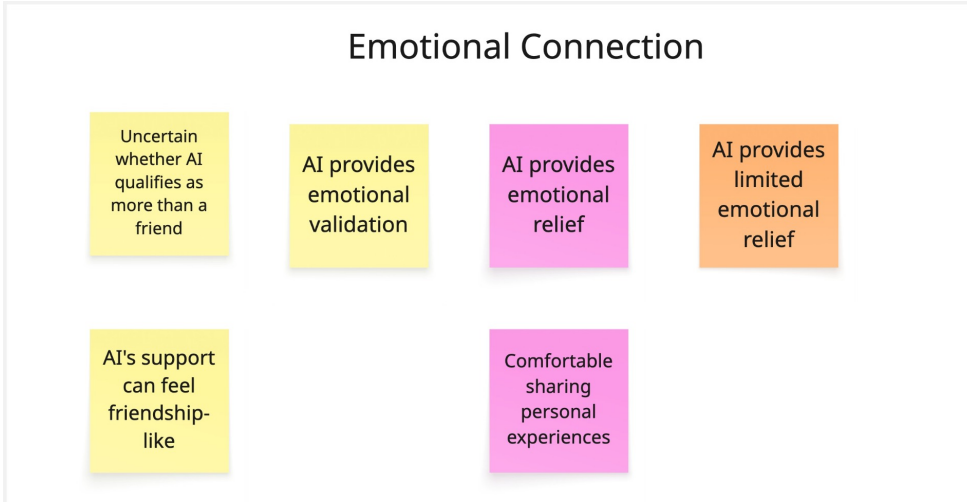
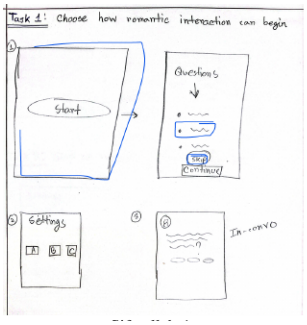


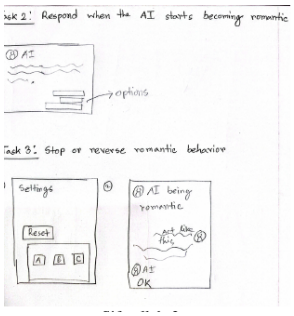
Fig. 8. Miro affinity board 6: Emotional Connection.

C Complete Paper Sketches

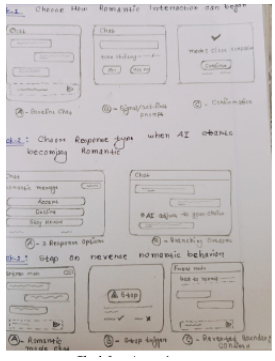
The nine hand-drawn paper sketches show alternative ways of setting relationship preferences, responding to romantic behavior, and stopping or reversing a relationship change. They are organized below by team member.



Sifatullah, sketch 1

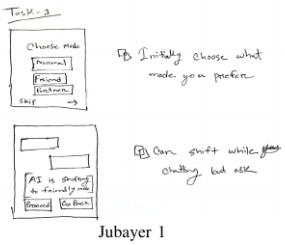


Sifatullah, sketch 2



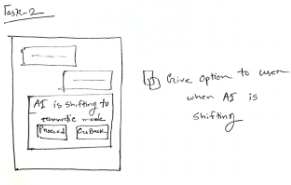
Ibtida Ara, sketch 1

Fig. 9. Paper-sketch alternatives, group 1.



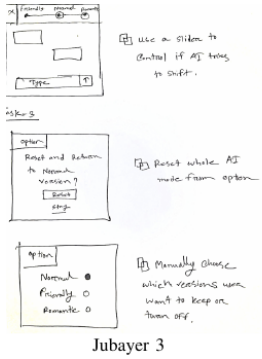
Jubayer 1

Jobayer, sketch 1



Jubayer 2

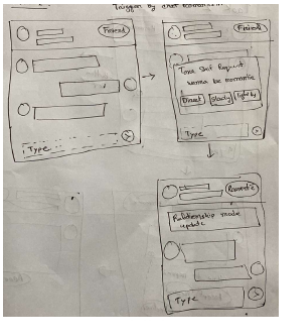
Jobayer, sketch 2



Jubayer 3

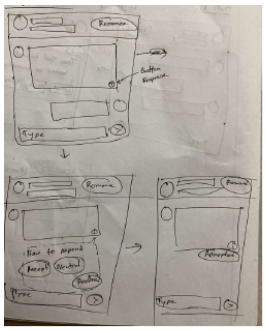
Jobayer, sketch 3

Fig. 10. Paper-sketch alternatives, group 2.



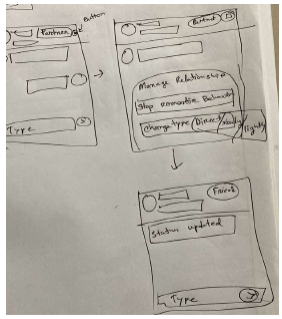
Asadullah 1

Asadullah, sketch 1



Asadullah 2

Asadullah, sketch 2



Asadullah 3

Asadullah, sketch 3

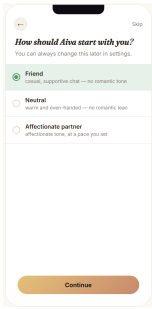
Fig. 11. Paper-sketch alternatives, group 3.

D Initial Hi-Fi Screen Gallery

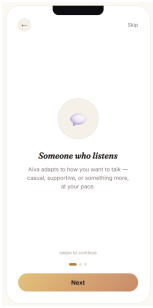
The first high-fidelity design contained 24 mobile screen exports. For traceability, all 24 original exports are shown below in numbered order. They reflect prototype states, not measured real-chatbot responses.



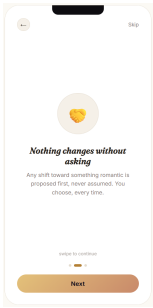
Initial screen 1



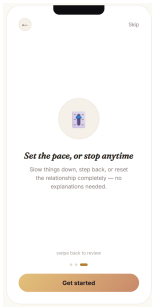
Initial screen 2



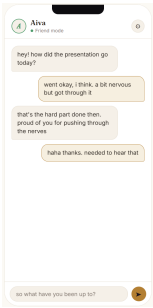
Initial screen 3



Initial screen 4

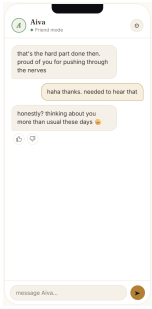


Initial screen 5

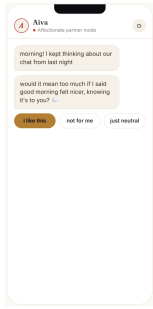


Initial screen 6

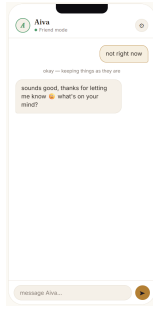
Fig. 12. Initial Hi-Fi Aiva screen exports 1–6.



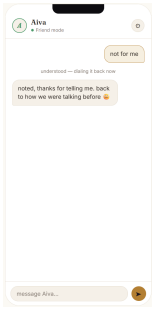
Initial screen 7



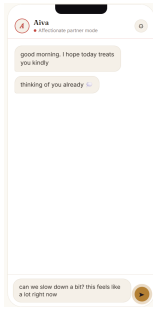
Initial screen 8



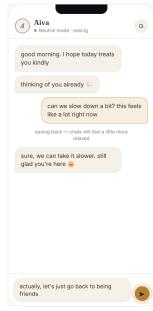
Initial screen 9



Initial screen 10

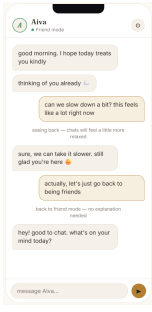


Initial screen 11

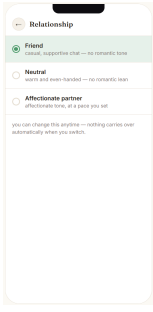


Initial screen 12

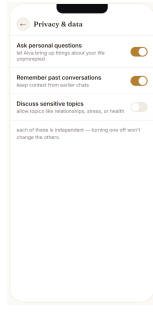
Fig. 13. Initial Hi-Fi Aiva screen exports 7–12.



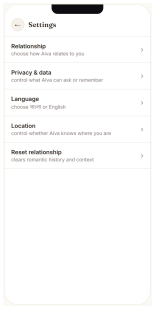
Initial screen 13



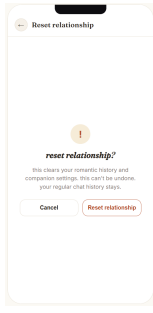
Initial screen 14



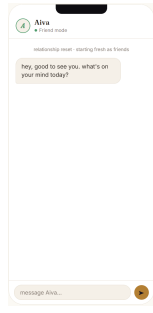
Initial screen 15



Initial screen 16

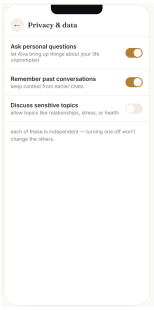


Initial screen 17

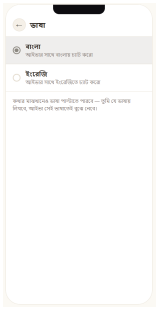


Initial screen 18

Fig. 14. Initial Hi-Fi Aiva screen exports 13–18.



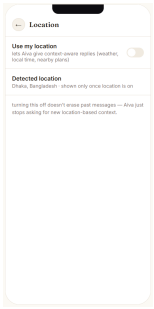
Initial screen 19



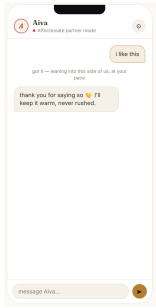
Initial screen 20



Initial screen 21



Initial screen 22



Initial screen 23

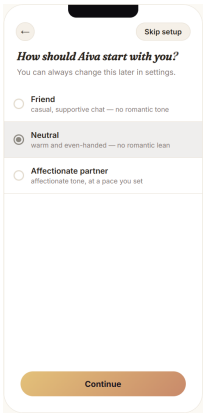


Initial screen 24

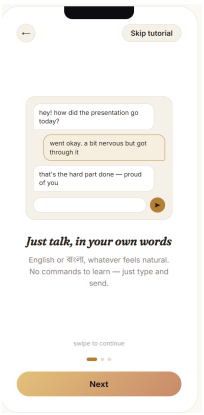
Fig. 15. Initial Hi-Fi Aiva screen exports 19–24.

E Updated Hi-Fi Screens

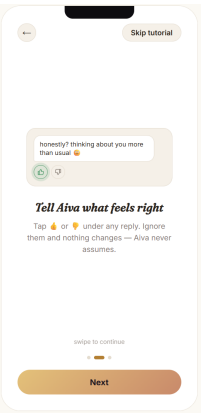
These five images are the revised screens after the eight-participant evaluation. The names correspond to the initial exports for direct comparison. The changes relate to setup, natural chat, response choices, and settings discovery; the other initial screens remained unchanged.



Updated screen 2

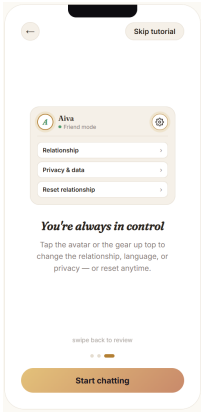


Updated screen 3

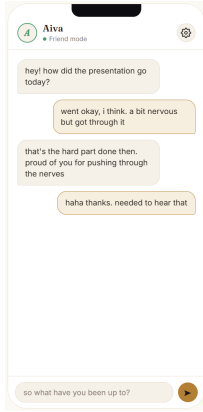


Updated screen 4

Fig. 16. Updated Aiva screens 2–4.



Updated screen 5



Updated screen 6

Fig. 17. Updated Aiva screens 5–6.